better for the people I loved—after all, wasn't that what everybody else did? But it was easier said than done. The denial, I mean. The money—that came easy. So easy that I felt guilty.

Counting Geneva, and not counting periodic trips home, I'd been away for nearly four years. The America I returned to felt like a changed country. I won't go as far as to say that I felt like a foreigner, but I did find myself mired in way too many conversations I didn't understand. Every other word was the name of some TV show or movie I didn't know, or a celebrity scandal I didn't care about, and I couldn't respond—I had nothing to respond with.

Contradictory thoughts rained down like *Tetris* blocks, and I struggled to sort them out—to make them disappear. I thought, pity these poor, sweet, innocent people—they're victims, watched by the government, watched by the very screens they worship. Then I thought: Shut up, stop being so dramatic—they're happy, they don't care, and you don't have to, either. Grow up, do your work, pay your bills. That's life.

A normal life was what Lindsay and I were hoping for. We were ready for the next stage and had decided to settle down. We had a nice backyard with a cherry tree that reminded me of a sweeter Japan, a spot on the Tama River where Lindsay and I had laughed and rolled around atop the fragrant carpet of Tokyo blossoms as we watched the *sakura* fall.

Lindsay was getting certified as a yoga instructor. I, meanwhile, was getting used to my new position—in sales.

One of the external vendors I'd worked with on EPICSHELTER ended up working for Dell, and convinced me that I was wasting my time with getting paid by the hour. I should get into the sales side of Dell's business, he said, where I could earn a fortune—for more ideas like EPICSHELTER. I'd be making an astronomical leap up the corporate ladder, and he'd be getting a substantial referral bonus. I was ready to be convinced, especially since it meant distracting myself from my growing sense of unease, which could only get me into trouble. The official job title was solutions consultant. It meant, in essence, that I had to solve the problems created by my new partner, whom I'm going to call Cliff, the account manager.

Cliff was supposed to be the face, and I was to be the brain. When we sat down with the CIA's technical royalty and purchasing agents, his job was to sell Dell's equipment and expertise by any means necessary. This meant reaching deep into the seat of his pants for unlimited slick promises as to how we'd do things for the agency, things that were definitely, definitely not possible for our